

THE MOUNTAIN ON FIRE

HUGO CUENOT



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I have an itch. I'm feeling restless and fidgety, and I'm not sure why. I pace around my room, thinking about nothing, but expecting something. I have no one to see, nowhere to be, nothing to do but to let this day pass by and time running between my fingers. But this restlessness doesn't really go away. So I put on my shoes and leave the house. The air is crisp outside, the pebbles from the alleyway crunch under my steps. I walk around the neighborhood. I walk fast, with large strides, thinking of nothing but the next step. The streets are clean but empty, I don't see anyone or hear anything. The buildings and houses I pass by seem empty, deserted. I keep on walking, pearls of sweat beading under my shirt. I start to go away from the neighborhood, take a turn on a dirt path, under a tree canopy. It doesn't look like somebody's driveway; patches of green grass sprinkled over the path. I slow down a bit, feeling better already. The tree canopy gives way to two large fields on each side.

I didn't even know they were growing crops so close to my place. The dirt road slowly starts to go uphill, leaving the fields behind, now flanked with bushes and rocks. The walk starts to get a little bit technical, I'm not wearing the right clothes for this, but I keep going, nonetheless. The sky above me opens up, the blue sky peeking behind the clouds, and I feel rejuvenated. I've never been on this trail, large rocks leading me up like a staircase, prickly bushes sticking at my pants and branches ready to take my head off. Still on I go, fully sweating now, but the dopamine rush of the effort is filling my heart, and emptying my mind. The silence, the wind, the rushing of the leaves, it is so uplifting to live through this hyper real experience without feeling alienated from the world, like turning on my white noise machine makes me feel sometimes.

I wasn't aware that such a rocky path existed behind my house, and I don't remember there being a hill either. The sky has completely cleared as I walked, now the sun is shining bright above me, reflecting the way on top of the smooth calcite rocks, making me walk on pure light. As I go up, the trees become more sparse, as do the bushes, leaving more room for rocks and light. I had been walking for forty minutes without a

break when a trickling stream of water appeared at my feet. The small stream is truly godsent as I have not brought any water with me, and with the sun being so hot all of a sudden, I'm in desperate need of a refreshment. I let some water fill up in my hands to splash it on my face and let it run along my back and my chest. Slowly the water replaces the sweat on my shirt, a dark stain at the front and back. Refreshed, I keep on walking. I see what appears to be the top of the hill in the distance, leading directly to the sky. The path is so steep that at this point I am walking with my hands on the ground, almost climbing. I reach the top and in front of me opens up a large plateau overlooking the city, and on the other side, the sea.

I look for my house, my street, but everything seems so alien from here. The city, sprawled almost infinitely before my eyes, doesn't resemble the city I know, it doesn't seem human scale. How can everyone I know and everywhere I have been could be in this grid that I can embrace with a single stare? I cannot believe it. Then the sea. It seems so close. I didn't know the sea was so close. I can hear it crashing on the cliffs, far out below me. It is roaring and angry today, warning us of something violent, but I don't think we're listening. So, it crashes again,

and again. The plateau doesn't fall down like a cliff but is sort of set down on top of the hill gently going down towards the city. It is quite luscious, not as much as at the bottom, but the bushes and small trees of dark green, dry and solid live strongly under the sun, rocked by the wind.

The wind carries with it a faint smell of the sea, and ruffles softly the leaves on its way. Somewhere behind me a bush ruffles a bit more strongly than the other ones. Snakes are common around here, as are small animals. But now I'm hearing breathing, and I get closer, slowly, walking cautiously, without a noise. The bush moves again, I stop for a second, afraid that whatever is inside has seen me. I stand still, petrified, a few centimeters away from the bush. The breathing has started again, feeling safe, I get closer, pushing the leaves apart and start peeking between the branches.

I hold my breath. After my eyes have adjusted to the dark, I see the figure making the noises I took for an animal. Two naked bodies, fusing with each other, clothes spread on the floor around them. I stand looking at them for a few seconds, they haven't noticed me, their chests stuck together, their legs intertwined, heads

thrown back. They're moving with the wind, a beautiful rocking motion, together, in unison. I don't want to keep being the voyeur so I leave them, relieved that no ugly animal was hiding, ready to attack me. I understand the urge to be together with someone in this place, removed from the world, suspended above the city, close to the sky, an earshot away from the sea. I leave them behind me and go the opposite direction. My perception changes now that I know that hidden guests lurk in the shadows of the bushes, behind rocks, maybe on treetops.

Now it feels like the mountain is screaming a coital orgasmic calling to me, coming from my feet, vibrating through my bones, going up my spine, going up my brains. I walk around but now; my senses start to pick up on things. A foot behind a rock, a laugh in the distance, now every bush is moving with something inside of it. I realize that this place is swarming with people, hidden together, having sex, enjoying themselves under the sun, protected. It is as if I am seeing for the first time a veil removed from my eyes, the flesh and the love now pouring on display.

I am no voyeur, I don't intend to indulge in this spectacle, but I want to be a part of it. I want to indulge in somebody else. Some bodies. I start

to walk down the small hill, towards a more intricate path of large rocks and hiding spots. I pass by more people sharing a moment, some offering it for everyone to enjoy, only deepening my wish to partake in the moment. A few solitary people are gravitating around, probably just like me, found their way here by chance and now bewitched by the beauty of the place and the moment that they have to stay and find their moment. The deep desire inside of me rises like the tides and comes crashing in my veins. In the distance, the face hidden in the branches, I notice a naked body, and I feel immediately attracted to it. I walk towards the body, he's alone, and like a beast, he sensed me as well.

My shirt is still wet from the water, and I keep sweating as I get closer to him. He's so tall his face is still hidden in the branches, my head looking straight at his chest. I put a hand on him, and spent a moment with him, in his embrace. I entered in his unknown the same way I came here, in this unknown. He looks like he belongs here, in this world, in his nakedness, in his generous nature. The hair covering his body just like the bushes and shrubs cover the mountain. His prick, hard against my skin like the tree he's leaning against. His bare feet resting on the rocks like the waves on the cliffs. His lan-

guorous kiss like the wind in my hair. His voice in my ears, like the sound of the hill. I undress for him, letting my skin touch a little bit of the sky, and the sweat to pearl down on the ground. We know nothing of each other but the outline of our skins, and the inside of our mouths, and our asses. I don't know the color of his heart but I know the color of his tip, and in some ways, it is enough for me, for today. We lie together on the ground, sharp rocks hitting my spine and my ribs, but the pain doesn't remove anything from the sweetness of the moment. We don't really talk, we just share a moment, an orgasm, and a silence interspersed with the sound of all the bushes sharing an orgasm and a moment together.

A wave of fatigue washes over me and I have to excuse myself from his company, putting my clothes on, leaving him a kiss on the cheek as I leave. I emerge from the canopy of the branches that embraced us like a womb, back under the sun now much lower than before. More than before, wandering bodies in search of companionship or a good view keep walking around me, following the rocky paths drawn by centuries of people and animals roaming here in quest of something to fulfill their souls. And fulfilled I am now, full of a sentiment of belon-

ging, of love and peace. Like I have finally found an answer to the restlessness that has been poisoning me for so long. It is as if the mountain has welcomed me as one of her children, free to drift around here as I please. Lighter, I pass by my siblings like I have always known them. And slowly, I start to make my way down, following the sun's way, hiding behind those hills in the distance. I keep my shoes in my hands; I want to keep feeling the ground beneath my feet as I make my way down. The small sharp pebbles lodging between my toes, and the vibration from the ground.

Like a god leaving Olympus I have to come back to the realm of the mortals, I have to leave the sunny rocks and shining sea for my brothers and sisters to keep enjoying. As I make my way down, dry leaves and bushes make room for the luscious and green plants that welcome me with their greasy smell. The smooth rocks leave room for the dirt road I started this journey on, softly leading back to the cold fields of grass and wheat. Back in the shadows, I make my way back to my neighborhood, back to civilization, my feet no longer yearn to feel the harsh and cold ground beneath them, so I put my shoes back on, and start walking slowly towards my house, looking behind me.

The stillness of the house, the sterilized scent of cleanliness and the smothering walls make me queasy. I take a shower, leaving dust and sweat running down my skin, but the simple smell of soap makes me nauseous, so I let the water fall on me like rain. I walk to my bed, still drenched, leaving puddles of water behind me and I let myself fall on the bed. Even the smell of detergent on the sheets is irritating tonight. I close my eyes, let my mind drift for a while, running free under the night sky.

Stars in the shape of men cutting the sky, flying figures fusing with the ground. But when I open my eyes, it is in this controlled loneliness, I go back to this feeling of emptiness. I crawl under the sheet, still wet and force myself to sleep. The following days are hard to go through, the idea of going to work, and going back home, extenuated, and repeating it over again feels soul crushing. I keep looking out for the mountain, for a sign, listening to the sea in the distance, for a message, or a calling. But the longer I stay away from it, the weaker their sound to my heart is. As days pass by and my mood crumbles, I am longing to go back. I keep having these dreams

of body parts swallowed by the ground, slowly buried, and from which large sequoia trees start to grow, their roots eating up the flesh and their branches reaching up high. In some dreams I start to climb the sequoia but halfway through I end up falling and wake up on impact in a jolt. But in other dreams, I find myself crying endlessly at the feet of the trees. They all have in common this very peculiar feeling every time I wake up, as if I never really wake up to reality but a piece of me is left behind in the dream behind me.

As time goes by, I go through my life a little bit more like a zombie every day, disconnected from myself, only expecting to go back. One morning, I passed by a man in the street, and I can swear that in the cut of his jaw, in the sheen of his skin, I had seen him on the mountain. But his eyes don't stop on me, maybe I'm not even here right now, I feel vaporous and absent, ghostly and transparent. Every day a bit more distant from myself, every day slightly more dispersed. Even the conversations I have don't feel real, somebody surely is using my mouth to talk, because it doesn't feel like I'm the one controlling it.

On the last day, my body feels like it is living on its own, and I'm just sitting behind a win-

dow, only a witness to my life. It feels like the only part of myself awake is simply yearning to go back to the mountain. All day, flashes of the view lit up in my head, and when finally I got home and crashed on the bed, suddenly a sort of relief washed over me and I fell asleep right there, still wearing my clothes, without eating anything, my mind forcing my body to skip time. I had a dreamless sleep that night. When I wake up and the low light of the early morning softly lights the room, an inescapable feeling of doom seems to linger in my still foggy mind. The feeling doesn't really get away as I get ready for the day. Washing my face in the bathroom sink helps to lift the fog, but the feeling of imminent catastrophe clings to me like a bad smell coming from within.

I see from the window a clear blue sky, announcing a comfortable day, I dress in consequence, clothes easy to remove and put on, lightweight and cut to show my body at its advantage. Like last time, I leave everything behind, but this time not pushed by any necessity to put an end to my restlessness, but a physical urge to go back. I stand in front of my door, hesitant to put shoes on.

I decide to put them on for the first part and to just dunk them and hide them once I get tired of them, so I can then start to walk barefoot. And that is exactly what I end up doing. I walk through the neighborhood like a machine, long strides, eating as much ground as possible. The way to the hill is clear as day in my mind, I follow the path I took before. When I reach the dirt path, I leave my shoes behind, free to walk barefoot. I follow the path, again, under the trees, along the fields. But the sky is darkening, large clouds are coming out. Still on I went, immersed in the feeling, my mind going blank as I climb.

But as I go, the feeling of dread and doom keeps growing, as the clouds in the sky. The sun is now completely gone, it is getting very dark, and something in the air doesn't feel right. Then a smell comes to me, the smell of something burning in the distance. A sense of panic starts to get to me. The air gets thicker as I climb, soon, small ash particles fly over to me, landing on my arms. Mixing with my sweat, my complexion takes an ashy tone, every particle falling on my skin getting stuck and dissolving on it. But I keep climbing, panicked by whatever is happening above. The ground, the trees and the bushes now have a fine pellicule of ash on top of them,

as if it had snowed from hell on the mountain. I stumble several times on rocks hidden under a dark grey carpet. Without realizing, I am now walking in a cloud of smoke, everything slowly getting hazy around me. I'm having a hard time breathing; I can feel the ash trying to get in my mouth and in my nose, I'm feeling filthy. Without the sun, nothing is casting any shadows, I'm simply walking in a world of grey. I would think that the absence of the sun would bring in a post-apocalyptic cold but on the contrary, a sort of warmth in the air makes me sweat profusely. I feel a sadness for the view I have had in mind for so many days, dreaming of scents and colors, and now I just see myself stuck on a hike on the dark side of the moon.

The sound of a trickle of water reminds me of where I am, and incapable of visually finding the small water source in this landscape, I follow the low noise to its source. At this height, everything is covered in ash, nothing has been spared. I find this band of ash moving where the trickling noise was coming from, where the water is moving under the ash blanket. I remove some of the ashes on top of the water and dip my hands in the cold water. I try to splash some of the clear water on my arms and my face, but

everything turns out grey, smudging a paste on my skin that starts to tingle. I try as best as I can to rinse it off but now it feels like the whole stream glimmers in a grey hue, tinting everything darker. I leave the poisoned stream behind me and get back on track.

The smoke is thick, the ash is falling denser, blinding me. This is the warmest snowstorm I've ever been in. Tears start falling down my face, my eyes watering beyond my control, running to furrows on my cheeks. But I keep climbing, my heart racing with dread and effort. I see the last climb to the top like the gate of heaven, however, when I get to the top, the thick smoke welcomes me as if I just entered a steam room. The warmth emanating from the air itself suffocates me from everywhere. The air is hard to breathe and visibility is close to none. The landscape is a vision coming straight from hell, a desolate land, bushes, trees and grass reduced to ashes in the wind, and if not, slowly going up in smoke, eaten by the embers, burning in a white heat in the artificial darkness. I look up at the sky, or what I think is the sky, the uniform grey background all around me, only pierced by a red circle above me that I imagine is the sun, angry at me for some reason. I walk around slowly, dreading to fall in a crater of lava or the

surface of the sun.

Some rocks refuse to collect any ash on them and remain tall, sharp and white, like teeth on a burnt corpse. I jump when I accidentally walk on a hot branch slowly burning, almost invisible under the ashes. There isn't one flame in sight, just low embers burning hotter than any fire, sometimes sending sparks in the distance. It is a very silent fire as well, I hear nothing, the sound swallowed by the smog. But soon, after carefully walking over a short distance, I start to see ghostly figures moving around me, the noise of their steps swallowed by the cushy floor and the smoke.

I'm not certain whether they're real or a figment of my mind lacking clean oxygen. I stop for a second and open my senses, trying to guide myself with the sounds. I hear cracking sounds on my left, and start to walk minutely in this direction, hoping that it won't be a pile of steaming branches. I can swear that something just brushed against my arm, but when I turn around, nothing. I keep walking into nothingness. This time I clearly feel a hand grazing my lower back. I'm sweating profusely, because not only does this place look like a post-apocalyptic sauna, but it also feels like one. Sweat pours down my skin

so profusely that the ash that has been stuck to it on my way up simply slides right off, my pores pushing it with the beading perspiration. I take off my shirt and wrap it around my face, trying to protect my nose and mouth from the smoke while letting my skin breathe to cool down.

This time I clearly see the outline of a body move and I start to move in its direction. I trip on a rock and almost end up in a black heap of burnt sticks, but something catches me before I fall on my face. A strong grip holds my arm firmly but without any hurt. A fully naked man stands next to me, completely grey from his feet to his knees, the rest of his body glistening, catching the light from the embers. His smile, much like the rocks piercing through the ashy duvet, showed white teeth shining in the end of the world. I mutter a few thanks that died in the shirt wrapped around my face.

He shrugs and motions me to follow him. I comply, following the agile man, walking into his steps, no longer the first man to walk on the moon. He leads me to a depression, a spot where the rocks make a hook where the fire and smoke haven't yet reached. There we can breathe and see clearly, a haven in the chaos. I remove the shirt from around my face so I can finally thank my savior. He stands in his naked glory

a few centimeters from me, his back against the rock to avoid the smoke as much as possible. I turn towards him and thank him, extending my hand to introduce myself. He shakes my hands and in a light voice gives me his name.

I look around and ask him if he knows what is going on here. He shrugs, and tells me that it happens more and more frequently, and that the people that come here have learned to live with it. There is no way to really fight it, there isn't enough water in the sea to kill all the fires, so you just have to live through it. When the smoke smothers you, you have to learn to stop breathing. When the ashes burn your skin, you have to learn to feel nothing. When the heat makes you parched you have to learn to find liquids. He licks my dripping neck as he says the last words. He kisses me a kiss of dust and sweat. He continues saying that around here, a place like this is so precious that forfeiting it to the calamity is not an option. This place is the guardian of so much love and softness, of so much sex and secrets; we cannot abandon it. The world is what it is, and we just have to live with it. This isn't the first time hell has been let loose; we've already learnt to sleep under a blanket of ash and dust on the remains of those who have

lost it for us.

He lightly puts a hand on my chest; his palm is cold and slightly moist. He leads me back to the furnace, outside of our little haven. He holds my hand while he leads me somewhere, now reduced to a shadow in the thick smoke. The red sun still above us, its rays still unable to reach us. As we walk, this time I can clearly hear moaning, kissing and bodies slamming softly against each other, the sound muffled in the air. Neither the smoke nor the ashes have deterred the lovers to be here, exactly as my companion had told me. We even pass by a group, busy together, having a wonderful time, their skin grey and black as the sky. They look like aliens, with too many limbs, somewhere on a strange planet, accomplishing a sacred and secret ritual. I left my shirt behind, dropped it on the floor but now my eyes are starting to itch and water. I can swear that something big just flew above our heads.

My guide stopped on a flat rock which is too slippery to keep any ash, dust or dirt from sitting on top of it. The stone is cold to the touch, and we sit down on it. We make love right there on top of the rock, offering a view to all the creatures hiding around us, because I can tell, in the corner of my eyes, that lurking creatures are fee-

ding off of the spectacle. But I'm generous, so I give it to them.

His body is hot against mine; we melt into each other. It's hot, uncomfortable, dirty and it hurts, but it is the best moment I've had. Hyper focused on my pleasure and his, I get startled by the hand that lands on my shoulder and slides down my back. Soon we're surrounded by several bodies who crossed the shadow, who have left their lurking to be part of this moment. We welcome them and like that we find ourselves mixing limbs and fluids while a rain of ash and acid starts to fall on us.

As my body starts splitting between all of them, my mind starts to scatter as well, going outside of my body, high above us, watching the bodies from above, going higher, seeing beyond the smoke, towards the sky, towards the sea in the distance, under the sun. Higher and higher I go, until my mind touches the moon, again I find myself in a crater of grey dust. I open my eyes only to find myself naked, alone. My eyes burn so much right now tears stream down my eyes continuously, rendering everything around me as a grey blur. I cannot find my clothes around me, my body speckled with stains of all sorts. Everything is still around me, most of the small

fires and burning embers have died out but the thick smoke remains. I look around, looking for someone, or something, a sign, or perhaps a noise. Footsteps sprawling everywhere in the ashes around me gives me no clear indication where I should start going.

A sense of peace has reached my heart, I'm feeling appeased. I'm thinking of looking for my way back down, to the real world. I get off the stone and start walking where my instinct leads me. I'm positive I came from that way, certain to recognize what remains of that tree. Every time I stumble and fall a cloud of dust rises around me and stays suspended for what seems to be an eternity. But I stand up, again and again. Now I'm walking blind, the tears and the dust making it impossible for me to see anything clearly. I hear a rushing sound in the distance, something low, I'm hoping for water to save me and my sight. I see shadows in the sky, and in the corner of my eyes, always right at the edge of my vision and they seem to disappear every time I turn my head towards them. There is a small depression in the ground, I carefully get down, making sure not to slip.

An ocean of grey is open in front of me, with my reduced vision, I cannot tell the sky from

the ground, but the water is near, the sound coming from somewhere in front of me. I take a few steps forward when it feels like my foot misses a step. My heart stops. It didn't miss a step; I missed a whole cliff. It is too late to try to save myself from the fall, I'm falling down towards the rushing sound of the water, a hundred meters below me. My last moments, falling off the smoke, I finally see clearly, the daylight reflecting on the blue sea below me, I'll finally be clean.